Nitzavim/Vayailech 5783

This week's פרשיות are ניצבים וילך, and include וילך, the shortest פרשה in the Torah. Nevertheless, it has a powerhouse full of wonderful things to learn, one of which is what we will do now from the וילנא גאון. In פרק ל״א פסוק י״ד, the pasuk says: וַיֹּאמֶר ה׳ אֶל מֹשֶׁה הֵן קָרְבוּ יָמֶיךָ לָמוּת קְרָא אֶת יְהוֹשֻׁעַ. A מדרש ילקוט, brought down in חתם סופר על התורה, says that the day that משה רבינו was going to be נפטר, Hashem's שכינה moved over to Yehoshua and was speaking to Yehoshua. שאל לו משה - Moshe asked Yehoshua; מה אמר לך ה׳ - What did Hashem tell you? אמר לו יהושע, וכי כל ארבעים שנה שאלתי אותך מה דיבר ה׳ - Yehoshua's answer to Moshe was, "And in all the 40 years, did I ever ask you what Hashem said?" Immediately משה רבינו said, טוב אלף מיתות מקנאה אחת - Better to die a thousand times than to have a moment of קנאה. A מדרש פלא׳דיגע from beginning to the end.

The first question is, is this the way that Yehoshua could possibly speak to משה רבינו under any circumstances? That's the obvious question. We are amazed to hear such a statement. And the second question is, what in fact did הקדוש ברוך הוא tell Yehoshua that was so vital, so important?

The וילנא גאון answers in a way that only the וילנא גאון could. הקדוש ברוך הוא wanted משה רבינו to pass away very calmly, with ישוב הדעת, he uses the words נפש חפיצה, willingly. We know that Moshe Rabbeinu davened 515 תפילות. One of his requests was that if indeed the time had come for Yehoshua to take over leadership - since אין מלכות אחת נוגעת בחברתה, two kings cannot rule at the same time - then let Yehoshua be the Rebbi and Moshe be the talmid. "At least", Moshe asked, "allow me to go into ארץ ישראל so I can perform the מצוות there. I don't want to die before I have this opportunity."

הקדוש ברוך הוא wanted to reveal to Moshe that he's not going to like it, שלא יהא זה לו לנחת - This will not be easy for him. In fact, he will not be able to tolerate it at all. Therefore, as usual, the two קשיות answer each other. What did Hashem tell Yehoshua? Hashem told him: when Moshe asks you "What did Hashem say to you?" you should respond, "And in all the forty years, did I ever ask you what Hashem said?" He was quoting Hashem's words exactly, word for word.

So for one split second, a millisecond, משה רבינו would think Yehoshua is saying such a thing, and he'll say to himself, I'd rather die than have קנאה. משה רבינו himself quickly realized that that's exactly what Hashem said to Yehoshua. But that one moment was enough to give him the קנאה to no longer want to go along with his הוה אמינא to be the talmid.

Then he has at the end of this וילנא גאון, דפח״ח. I did not know what those four letters were, so I asked a few people and ended up calling R' Hershel Schachter, who told me, and I wrote it in my sefer here, דפח״ח is דברי פי חכם חן - The words of a wise man are very pleasant, are very beautiful.

So this is a tremendous וילנא גאון on the פרשה teaches us that everything is for our own good. הקדוש ברוך הוא פירט די וועלט, and no matter what happens to us, we have to be מקבל it. As it says in פרקי אבות, we have to be מקבל it with שמחה. אם ירצה ה׳, we should have יאר א גוט געבענטשט געזונט, daven that Hashem should not send us נסיונות, and in fact give us אריכות ימים, נחת from the קינדער, opportunities to do more and more מצוות, and that we should be זוכה to see ביאת גואל צדק this year.

https://youtu.be/bK4XW26PF4g